

salad to serve four people on one piece of meat, etc. The second way is to combine one or two high-end items as featured meal elements or make a high-end side or appetizer. For example, one pound of shrimp can make a decadent dinner for two, of shrimp cocktail for several.

#### 4. DIY

Using or getting your own skills can hide any-sized budget from others. Take some classes in photography, sewing, flower arranging, etc., and you'll find that having a personal area of expertise can really bump up your lifestyle a few notches.

#### 5. Bartering

This is related to the previous tip, but rather than using your skills for yourself, you can offer your skill to others, for the same price of their skills. This doesn't just apply to swapping casseroles for homemade jellies. Consider stretching your parameters a bit. How about a custom interior paint job in exchange for a bathroom remodel minus the cost of supplies on each? A few quarts of gourmet hummus swapped for an hour of professional massage therapy? Refurnished serving buffet for a professionally painted family portrait? Using those DIY

skills as a form of currency can help you get what you want without laying out cash.

#### 6. Budget ingredients with high-end style

Frozen spinach for a Mediterranean cheese log, boxed wine for marinades and mulling, basic dry goods for biscotti on the cheap, repurposing and refinishing thrift furniture, salvage and hardware materials for custom storage and DIY pot racks . . . lots of options are out there to implement the unexpected for a high-end result.

#### 7. The classics

Whether you pay closer to full price and own fewer clothing items or hunt for classic wardrobe items online and at thrift stores, the styles will be stable and the quality above par. Having fewer items to take care of that will stand the test of time is the way to go. You can also apply this strategy when power-shopping for vehicles. Certain classic models (even used) hold their value better than others. Volvo is a good example.

#### 8. Explore

Be open-minded about every penny-pinching method available, particularly when they are methods that